

PDFsam Basic Manual

Version 1.0 · September 2026

Independent community guide · First public release

This is the first public release. The manual will be expanded and corrected based on testing, software updates, and community feedback.

Contents

- Overview and suitability
- Core workflows: merge, split, mix, rotate, extract
- Output file naming
- Silent installation
- Troubleshooting memory errors
- Linux / OpenJDK notes
- Workspaces and repeated-page insertion
- System properties, runtime arguments, MSI properties, environment variables

Description

PDFsam or PDFsam Basic is a free, open source program that allows you to perform various PDF actions such as merge, split, page rotation, mix, extract and more. It is a great alternative for those who need to perform basic PDF actions.

The page lists packages for Windows, portable Windows, Linux, and macOS. Use that package information to match the download with the operating system, device, and workflow you intend to use.

PDFsam Features

The most useful PDFsam features are the ones tied directly to opening source files, choosing a PDF action, checking output quality, and saving or sharing the document. Those details help users decide whether the software fits the job before installation.

The feature list connects the page's existing description with practical setup, compatibility, and day-to-day use decisions. PDFsam is built around creating, reading, splitting, merging, converting, or preparing PDF documents.

PDFsam or PDFsam Basic is a free, open source program that allows you to perform various PDF actions such as; merge, split, page rotation, mix, extract and more.

It is a great alternative for those who need to perform basic PDF actions. PDF creation or handling for common document workflows. Tools may include merge, split, print, conversion, or review options. Useful for forms, reports, manuals, invoices, and archives. Helps standardize documents before sharing.

PDFsam Review

This PDFsam review focuses on practical fit: what the software is trying to do, how it should be assessed, and what users should check before relying on it.

The strongest reason to consider PDFsam is its fit for creating, reading, splitting, merging, converting, or preparing PDF documents. The main trade-off is that users still need to confirm platform support, file compatibility, and maintenance expectations.

"PDFsam is practical for firms that regularly need to split, merge, or reorder PDF documents without turning a straightforward task into a larger production. For a legal team like ours, case files, contracts, exhibits, and supporting records often arrive in separate pieces, so being able to assemble or separate them quickly saves time during case preparation," says Alex Freeburg from [Freeburg Law](#).

Document Workflow

PDFsam should make the main workflow clear from the first session. Users need to understand where to start, which files, accounts, devices, or settings are involved, and how to confirm that the software has produced the expected result.

That matters because opening source files, choosing a PDF action, checking output quality, and saving or sharing the document can become frustrating when essential controls are hidden or when the tool encourages changes before users have reviewed them. PDFsam is strongest when it keeps the core task visible and reversible where possible.

Output and Compatibility

Setup should be checked against the package listed on the page, the operating system in use, and any files, devices, accounts, or formats involved in the workflow. The page lists packages for Windows, portable Windows, Linux, and macOS.

Document tools should be tested with important forms or legal files before relying on them for production work. Users working on important files, system settings, backups, media, or shared devices should test with non-critical material before depending on the software for regular work.

Who Should Download PDFsam?

Download PDFsam if you need a PDF utility for creating, reading, splitting, merging, converting, or preparing PDF documents and prefer a dedicated tool over a broader suite. It is especially relevant when the task is repeated often enough that a purpose-built application saves time.

PDFsam may be less useful if the same job is already covered by the operating system, a browser-based service, or a more complete professional package. Before installing, confirm that the listed build and expected workflow match the job you actually need to complete.

How to combine PDF files with PDFsam Basic

1. Drag and drop the PDF files you want to merge
2. Arrange your files in the desired order
3. Select the resulting PDF file name
4. Click Run to combine the files

How to split PDF files with PDFsam Basic

1. Drag and drop the PDF file you want to split
2. Choose how to split it: by page numbers, by bookmark level, or by file size
3. Set the options for the selected split method
4. Click Run to split the file

Split by page numbers

Split at every page, at even or odd pages, at a custom list of page numbers, or every "n" pages. You decide exactly where each new PDF file begins.

Split by size

Split a large PDF file into several smaller documents of a target size, in megabytes or kilobytes. Handy when you need to email a file or stay under an upload size limit.

Split by bookmarks

Split a PDF file at a chosen bookmark tree depth level, for example splitting a book into one file per chapter. An optional regular expression lets you match only specific bookmarks.

How to interleave and mix PDF files with PDFsam Basic

1. Drag and drop the two or more PDF files you want to mix
2. Set the pace, i.e. how many pages to take from each file before switching to the next one
3. Enable reverse order for any file that was scanned back to front
4. Click Run to mix the files

Fix single-sided scans

If your scanner only scans one side at a time, it produces two separate files: one with the odd pages, one with the even pages. Mix them back together and recreate the original double-sided document.

Reverse order for flipped stacks

Many scanners flip the paper stack before scanning the back sides, so the second file comes out in reverse order. Enable the Reverse option on that file and PDFsam Basic will read its pages back to front.

Custom pace between files

Not just one page at a time: set the Pace to take two or more consecutive pages from a file before switching to the next one.

How to rotate PDF files with PDFsam Basic

1. Drag and drop one or multiple PDF files you want to rotate
2. Choose which pages to rotate: all pages, even pages, odd pages, or a page range
3. Select the rotation angle
4. Click Run to rotate the files

Bulk rotation for multiple files

1. Add several PDF files at once and rotate them all in a single run, saving time when processing large batches of documents.
2. Rotate all, even or odd pages
3. Permanently rotate every page, or apply the rotation only to even or odd pages, handy when you need to fix pages that came out upside-down from a double-sided scan.

Rotate a specific page range

Rotate only the pages you need, for example just the last 10 pages of a long document, using flexible page ranges like 2-13,17 or an open-ended range such as 20-.

How to extract PDF pages with PDFsam Basic

1. Drag and drop one or multiple PDF files you want to extract pages from
2. Set the pages or page ranges to extract, for example 2,5-7,12-
3. Optionally choose to generate a separate file for each page range
4. Click Run to extract the pages

Bulk extraction from multiple files

1. Add several PDF files at once and extract the same pages or page ranges from all of them in a single run, saving time when processing large batches of documents.
2. One file per page range
3. Extract multiple page ranges and choose whether to save them all in one document, or generate a separate PDF file for each page range in the set.

Flexible page selection

Select pages using single numbers, ranges, open-ended ranges or the "last" keyword, for example 2, 5-7, 12- or last.

How to customize file names with PDFsam Basic

Special keywords can be used as placeholders in the output file names, to be replaced with dynamic values during the execution. The set of available keywords depends on the module you are using. Right click on the text field of the File names settings panel to find out what are the available keywords

▼ File names settings

Generated PDF documents name prefix: PDFsam_

[CURRENTPAGE]

Replaced by the current page number in the input document.

Examples:

[CURRENTPAGE###] generates three digits filenames like 001.pdf, 002.pdf

[CURRENTPAGE12] generates filenames starting from 13, i.e. 13.pdf, 14.pdf

[CURRENTPAGE###12] generates three digits filenames starting from 13, i.e. 013.pdf, 014.pdf

[TIMESTAMP]

Replaced by the current date and time.

[FILENUMBER]

Replaced by the current file number.

Examples:

[FILENUMBER###] generates three digits filenames like 001.pdf, 002.pdf

[FILENUMBER12] generates filenames starting from 13, i.e. 13.pdf, 14.pdf

[FILENUMBER###12] generates three digits filenames starting from 13, i.e. 013.pdf, 014.pdf

[BASENAME]

Replaced by the original file name (without extension), it must be used together with other placeholders ensuring unique names.

Examples:

[CURRENTPAGE]_[BASENAME] generates 1_input-file.pdf, 3_input-file.pdf, etc

[TOTAL_FILENUMBER]

Replaced by the total number of generated PDF files.

Examples:

If the task created a total of 12 PDF files,
[FILENUMBER]_of_[TOTAL_FILENUMBER] generates 1_of_12.pdf,
2_of_12.pdf, etc

[BOOKMARK_NAME]

Replaced by the current bookmark name and only applicable when splitting by bookmarks.

Examples:

[CURRENTPAGE]_[BOOKMARK_NAME] generates 1-Introduction.pdf, 4-Chapter 1.pdf, etc

[BOOKMARK_NAME_STRICT]

Same as [BOOKMARK_NAME] with the difference that non-alphanumeric characters are removed.

How to silent install with PDFsam Basic

PDFsam Basic MSI can be used to perform a silent install on Windows machines. Some properties are available and can be used during the silent install to drive some setting in PDFsam, [here is the list](#) together with some runtime arguments or System properties you can use to change PDFsam default behavior.

MSI silent install example

```
msiexec /i "pdfsam-6.0.5.msi" /qb /norestart CHECK_FOR_UPDATES=false  
DONATE_NOTIFICATION=false SKIPTHANKSPAGE=Yes
```

Map failed and OutOfMemoryError

How to resolve Map failed and OutOfMemoryError

Map failed

You are splitting PDF files and they are big, so big that PDFsam Basic choked with these last words?

```
Caused by: java.io.IOException: Map failed  
at sun.nio.ch.FileChannelImpl.map(Unknown Source) ~[na:1.8.0_31]  
at  
org.sejda.io.MemoryMappedSeekableSource.(MemoryMappedSeekableSource.java:59) ~[pdfsam-community-3.0.1.RELEASE.jar:na]  
at org.sejda.io.SeekableSources.seekableSourceFrom(SeekableSources.java:74) ~[pdfsam-community-3.0.1.RELEASE.jar:na]  
at  
org.sejda.impl.sambox.component.DefaultPdfSourceOpener.open(DefaultPdfSourceOpener.java:61) ~[pdfsam-community-3.0.1.RELEASE.jar:na]  
... 12 common frames omitted  
Caused by: java.lang.OutOfMemoryError: Map failed  
at sun.nio.ch.FileChannelImpl.map0(Native Method) ~[na:1.8.0_31]
```


Solution: If you are on a 64-bit operating system, make sure you are running PDFsam Basic version 4 or higher

Java heap space

This is different, still an OutOfMemoryError but with a different cause, see the Java heap space in place of the Map failed?

```
java.lang.OutOfMemoryError: Java heap space
    at
    org.sejda.io.MemoryMappedSeekableSource.readPage(MemoryMappedSeekable
    Source.java:120)
    at
    org.sejda.io.MemoryMappedSeekableSource.read(MemoryMappedSeekableSour
    ce.java:100)
    at
    org.sejda.io.BufferedSeekableSource.ensureBuffer(BufferedSeekableSource.java:
    110)
    at
    org.sejda.io.BufferedSeekableSource.read(BufferedSeekableSource.java:100)
```

Solution:

Version 4: Use a text editor to open the pdfsam.l4j.ini text file in the PDFsam Basic installation directory, find this row -Xmx512m which tells PDFsam Basic to run with 512MB of heap memory, change it to -Xmx1024m rising the amount of memory to 1GB and restart PDFsam Basic. If that doesn't work you can try pushing it even higher with -Xmx1512m

Version 5: Use a text editor to open the pdfsam.cfg text file in the PDFsam Basic app subdirectory, find the [JavaOptions] section and add a row java-options=-Xmx1024m rising the amount of memory to 1GB and restart PDFsam Basic. If that doesn't work you can try pushing it even higher with -Xmx1512m

PDFsam Basic version 3 on Linux with OpenJDK

How to run PDFsam Basic on Linux using OpenJDK

Starting with version 4, PDFsam Basic is distributed including a simplified version of the Java runtime used to run the application. It is no longer necessary to install Java.

PDFsam Basic v3.x requires Java 8 with JavaFX installed. JavaFX is included in [Oracle Java Runtime Environment](#), what about [OpenJDK](#)?

```
java.lang.NoClassDefFoundError: javafx/application/Application
```

Some Linux distributions have separate packages for OpenJDK and JavaFX so, if you install the OpenJDK package and try to run PDFsam 3.x, you get an error because of the missing JavaFX :

```
Exception in thread "main" java.lang.NoClassDefFoundError:
javafx/application/Application
```

```
    at java.lang.ClassLoader.defineClass1(Native Method)
    at java.lang.ClassLoader.defineClass(ClassLoader.java:760)
    at java.security.SecureClassLoader.defineClass(SecureClassLoader.java:142)
    at java.net.URLClassLoader.defineClass(URLClassLoader.java:467)
    at java.net.URLClassLoader.access$100(URLClassLoader.java:73)
    at java.net.URLClassLoader$1.run(URLClassLoader.java:368)
    at java.net.URLClassLoader$1.run(URLClassLoader.java:362)
    at java.security.AccessController.doPrivileged(Native Method)
    at java.net.URLClassLoader.findClass(URLClassLoader.java:361)
    at java.lang.ClassLoader.loadClass(ClassLoader.java:424)
    at sun.misc.Launcher$AppClassLoader.loadClass(Launcher.java:331)
    at java.lang.ClassLoader.loadClass(ClassLoader.java:357)
    at org.pdfsam.community.App.main(App.java:34)
```

Caused by: java.lang.ClassNotFoundException: javafx.application.Application

```
    at java.net.URLClassLoader.findClass(URLClassLoader.java:381)
    at java.lang.ClassLoader.loadClass(ClassLoader.java:424)
    at sun.misc.Launcher$AppClassLoader.loadClass(Launcher.java:331)
    at java.lang.ClassLoader.loadClass(ClassLoader.java:357)
    ... 13 more
```

Solution: Install the [openjfx](#) package for your Linux distribution

PDFsam Basic workspaces

How to use workspaces in PDFsam Basic

Using workspaces in PDFsam Basic it is possible to save the configuration of the various tools available. This allows you to restore frequently used settings with just a few clicks and allows you to have several saved configurations, which can be reloaded as needed.

In the PDFsam Basic settings it is also possible to set a workspace to be loaded when the application is started. This allows those who have recurring jobs with always the same settings to speed things up and save time.

How to insert PDF pages multiple times with PDFsam Basic

Drag and drop the PDF file you want to insert pages to

Drag and drop the PDF file whose pages will be repeated

Select what page or pages will be repeated

Select after how many pages to repeat

Select the resulting PDF file name

Click Run to insert pages

Flexible settings

PDFsam Basic allows you to specify how many pages to repeat and after how many pages to repeat.

Completely free

PDFsam Basic is free and open source since 2006. Merge your PDF files, with no signup, no size limit and no credit card.

Perfect for the print industry

Print companies usually have unique job requirements. If you need to generate a PDF file where every odd page of the file must be the same, PDFsam Basic can do it.

Properties and arguments

Andrea Vacondio edited this page on Oct 28, 2024 · [15 revisions](#)

System properties

A list of system properties that users can configure to alter PDFsam behavior.

org.pdfsam.disable.ui.restore

values: true|false

default: false

description: if set to true PDFsam will not restore the stage position, dimensions and mode, it will start with default values instead (maximized).

org.pdfsam.default.locale

values: a supported locale

default: default locale

description: if no locale is set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam to use this locale.

org.pdfsam.default.checkforupdate

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should check for updates at startup.

org.pdfsam.default.checkfornews

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should check for news at startup.

org.pdfsam.default.play.sounds

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should play alert sounds.

org.pdfsam.disable.split.optimization

values: true|false

default: false

description: if set to true PDFsam will not try to optimize split tasks result files.

org.pdfsam.default.donate.notification

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should show the notification to kindly ask for a donation.

org.pdfsam.default.fetch.premium.modules

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should fetch and show premium modules description in the modules dashboard

@deprecated

org.pdfsam.settings.panel

values: true|false

default: false

description: deprecated, use org.pdfsam.disable.settings.panel

since: 4.0.0

org.pdfsam.disable.settings.panel

values: true|false

default: false

description: if set to true, PDFsam will start without the settings panel

since: 4.0.1

org.pdfsam.default.compression

values: true|false
default: true
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells the default value of the "Compress output file" checkbox
since: 4.2.0

org.pdfsam.default.output.override

values: true|false
default: false
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells the default value of the "Override if already exists" checkbox
since: 4.2.0

org.pdfsam.default.discard.bookmarks

values: true|false
default: false
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells the default value of the "Discard bookmarks" checkbox
since: 5.2.0

org.pdfsam.default.prefix

values: a prefix
default: default prefix
description: if no prefix is set in the application preferences, tells the default value for the "Prefix" field.
since: 5.2.0

org.pdfsam.default.pdf.version

values: VERSION_1_2|VERSION_1_3|VERSION_1_4|VERSION_1_5|VERSION_1_7|VERSION_2_0
default: VERSION_1_5
description: if no prefix is set in the application preferences, tells the default value for the output PDF version.
since: 5.2.9

Runtime arguments

-c

-clean

--clean

description: clears user preferences and locally stored information, starting PDFsam with default values.

-v

-verbose

--verbose

description: sets log levels to DEBUG providing a verbose output.
since: 4.0.1

--workspace="/path/to/workspace"

description: loads the given workspace. This has precedence over the application settings.

/path/to/file1.pdf

/path/to/file2.pdf

description: a list of PDF files to be opened with PDFsam.

MSI properties

A list of properties that can be set during the silent installation of the PDFsam MSI package.

CHECK_FOR_UPDATES

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should check for updates at startup.

CHECK_FOR_NEWS

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should check for news at startup.

since: 3.2.5

PLAY_SOUNDS

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should play alert sounds.

since: 3.2.5

DONATE_NOTIFICATION

values: true|false

default: true

description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should show the notification to kindly ask for a donation.

since: 3.2.1

LOCALE_CODE

values: a supported locale
default: default locale
description: if no locale is set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam to use this locale.

SKIPTHANKSPAGE

values: Yes|No
default: No
description: Tells the MSI installer to skip or not the thanks page that is usually opened once the installation completes successfully.

PREMIUM_MODULES

values: true|false
default: true
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells PDFsam if it should fetch and show premium modules description in the modules dashboard.
since: 3.2.5

PDF_COMPRESSION

values: true|false
default: true
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells the default value of the "Compress output file" checkbox
since: 4.2.0

OVERWRITE_OUTPUT

values: true|false
default: false
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells the default value of the "Overwrite if already exists" checkbox
since: 4.2.0

PREFIX

values: a string prefix
default: empty
description: if not already set in the application preferences, tells the default value of the "Prefix" field
since: 5.2.0

PDF_VERSION

values:

VERSION_1_2|VERSION_1_3|VERSION_1_4|VERSION_1_5|VERSION_1_7|
VERSION_2_0

default:

VERSION_1_5

description: if no prefix is set in the application preferences, tells the default value
for the output PDF version.

since: 5.2.9

Environment variables

An OpenJDK runtime is bundled since PDFsam Basic 4.0.0 but you can specify the path of a runtime installed on your machine using the environment variable called PDFSAM_JAVA_PATH and running PDFsam using one of the provided scripts in the bin subdirectory.

Release notes and feedback

Version 1.0 is the first public release of this manual. It is intentionally a practical starting point rather than a claim of completeness. Future releases can incorporate verified corrections, additional examples, screenshots, software-version changes, and useful community feedback.

Feedback and contributions

Found an error or a better way? Help improve the next release. When the project repository is published, corrections and suggestions can be collected there and reviewed before inclusion in a future version.

Changelog

Version	Date	Notes
1.0	September 2026	Initial public release

Project note

This is an independent community guide and is not official PDFsam documentation. Product names and trademarks belong to their respective owners. Readers should verify important workflows with non-critical files before using them in production.

Support

If this guide is useful, optional support information may be added to the project's public release page. Access to the manual itself does not depend on a donation.